

STATE INCENTIVE
Nitish Kumar gives a cheque of Rs 1 lakh to an inter-caste couple

BIHAR

KNOTS AGAINST CASTE

By Amitabh Srivastava

When Seema announced her decision to marry Rahul Anand two years ago, her Yadav family in Patna was anything but pleased. Rahul, after all, belonged to the privileged Bhumihar caste—part of the landowning elite and proud of their traditionally dominant status in Bihar's caste hierarchy—while the Yadavs symbolise the more recent upward mobility and empowerment of the better-off intermediate castes among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). "My kin feared I would be abused and then left to fend for myself," recalls Seema, a graduate from Patna Commerce College. Even her Yadav friends mocked her, asking whether she found nobody from her own caste good enough to marry her. But Seema went ahead and married Rahul in June 2020, just a week after he landed a set designer's job in Mumbai. Now the couple have a three-month-old daughter, but Seema's father, a real estate agent, is yet to accept the alliance.

Seema and Rahul share their story with very many other young couples—indeed, there seems to be quite a groundswell of rebellion against traditional caste endogamy among Bihar's youth. In 2021 alone, some 332 couples registered for—and received—the grant of Rs 1 lakh the state social welfare department offers to inter-caste unions. Small numbers? Consider this: that's almost an inter-caste couple a day, daring to come out in the open, in a deeply caste-ridden society. And official numbers are always the tip of the iceberg in India. The true extent of what's happening on the ground cannot be fully mapped, but it leaves plenty traces on all-pervasive social media spaces.

What these couples are fighting against is a complex caste matrix. Take Seema and Rahul. The Bhumihars and Yadavs, though largely coexisting peacefully, are often pitted as stark opponents politically—the former are